

BERNERA NEWS

A Community Newsletter 
in association with

COVID UPDATE

Welcome to the July / August edition of the Bernera News.

We've been very busy of late, as we're sure you all have, making the most of a gorgeous Hebridean summer, and enjoying spending time with family and friends now that covid restrictions have been eased.

With a spate of recent cases, however, comes a reminder that we still need to act responsibly in order to keep our community safe.

Contact us at: 01851 600 159

Text/Whatsapp: 07958 549784

Email: hello@thedailyceilidh.co.uk

Or visit us online at:

www.thedailyceilidh.co.uk

As of Monday 9th August, Scotland will move beyond level 0 of its coronavirus restrictions. This means that all businesses will be able to open, physical distancing is no longer required, and the limit on numbers for gatherings (both indoor and outdoor, private and public) has been lifted to 2000 indoor and 5000 outdoor.

However, some restrictions will continue: It will continue to be the law that face coverings must be worn in indoor public places and on public transport (exemptions will still apply). Test and protect will continue to operate, and therefore indoor hospitality and similar venues will still be required to collect the contact details of customers.

It should be noted that good hygiene practices are still to be encouraged, including the use of regular and efficient hand washing; the regular cleaning of surfaces with a suitable antibacterial product; and the covering of one's mouth and nose when coughing or sneezing.

In addition, NHS Western Isles are encouraging everyone to carry out Lateral Flow Tests regularly, but in particular if you are travelling to or from the Western Isles. These tests are for people who are

asymptomatic (showing no signs of illness).

Everyone can now get two free Covid-19 tests every week. To access testing please call the NHS Western Isles Covid line on **01851 601151** or order online at <https://bit.ly/3hECS9R>

If you have any symptoms at all please self-isolate and arrange a PCR test through the NHS by contacting **01851 601551** or email wi.covid19queries@nhs.scot

The phone lines have been very busy of late and so if you cannot get through you are asked to leave a message.

For those who are not already vaccinated and wanting to be, and are aged 18 or over on 31/10/21, you can contact NHS Western Isles to arrange a vaccination appointment. To book call **0808 196 8383** or email wi.covidvax@nhs.scot

SUNFLOWER COMPETITION

For all of you taking part in our sunflower competition, we hope that the recent sunshine and warm weather have helped. One of ours has become too big for the greenhouse so is now braving it outside, so we're very much hoping that the weather continues to behave itself, and any storms hold off for a little longer yet!

Don't forget that in order to be in with a chance of winning the prize, we need your entries by 15th September. To enter, simply submit a photo of your sunflower, with your name, contact details and the height of your flower in centimetres to **hello@thedailyceilidh.co.uk** or by whatsapp to **07958 549784**. If you don't have access to email or whatsapp, then give us a ring on **01851 600159** and we'll pop round and take a photo and measurement for you.

We can't wait to see how you've all got on!

BERNERA BAKES AT BERNERA CAFE

We are sure, like us, everyone is delighted to see the Bernera Cafe back open again, in the competent hands of Careen and her team.

Serving Careen's delicious cakes, as well as hot drinks and yummy food, the cafe is currently open:

Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday and Friday from 12.00 until 4pm, with hot food served until 3pm, and Saturday 11am until 3pm.

We all wish Careen the very best with her new venture, but don't forget that the only way she can continue is with our support. So, if you're feeling hungry or thirsty, why not pop down and test out the new menu and try some of her delicious food!



VOLUNTEERING

Do you have a few hours to spare? Would you like to help out in your community?

Volunteer Centre Western Isles have a number of volunteering activities you can get involved in, with a wide range of organisations, charities, community groups, and clubs. Some opportunities are a one off whilst others are a few hours a month - there is something for everyone.

Volunteering can help you:

- Boost your confidence
- Meet new people
- Gain experience
- Develop your CV
- Learn new skills
- Gain a reference to take to employers or college / university

If you think that you might like to become a volunteer why not call in to the Volunteer Centre at 95 Cromwell Street, Stornoway, or give them a call on **01851 700366**.

You can email them too at **info@volunteercentrewi.org**

ENERGY MEASURES PROJECT

Would you like to improve your home, become more energy efficient and save money?

Tighean Innse Gall's Energy Measures team can help you with a bespoke energy plan as well as advice and continuing support. Call **01851 706121** and leave a message with your name and contact telephone number, or email **charlie.healey@tighean.co.uk**

WATER

With the recent dry spell Scottish Water is asking people in the Western Isles to help take care of vital drinking water resources we all rely on by making small changes and using water efficiently this summer, and year-round.

For example:

- Taking shorter showers
 - Turning the water off when brushing your teeth
 - Using washing machines and dishwashers only when fully loaded
 - Using a watering can instead of a garden hose
-

MIANN NA MAIGHDINN-MARA 2 / MERMAID TALES 2

Following the success of our first series, we are shortly going to start filming series 2. The focus this time is on our offshore islands and we would love your input!

Do you have any lesser-known or unusual stories about any of our islands: Mealista, Scarp, Taransay, Flannan Isles, St Kilda or any others, even if they're tiny? If you do, please contact Kate at **kate@mactv.co.uk** or phone Ross on **0791762422**



BERNERA BAKES...COFFEE AND WALNUT CAKE

Ingredients:

- 1 tbsp instant coffee
- 1 tbsp hot water
- 175g self raising flour
- 1 1/2 level teaspoons of baking powder
- 175g caster sugar
- 175g soft margarine or butter
- 3 large eggs, beaten
- 75g walnuts, finely chopped

Method:

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (fan 160°C), gas mark 4.
2. Grease and line the base of two 18cm sandwich tins with baking parchment.
3. Dissolve coffee in the hot water and cool.
4. Sift the flour and baking powder into a large bowl. Add remaining ingredients and whisk together until all the ingredients are thoroughly blended.

5. Turn into prepared tins and level the surface.
6. Bake for 25 to 30 minutes until well risen, golden and firm to the touch.
7. Allow to cool in the tin for five minutes then turn out on a wire rack.
8. Once cooled completely, sandwich together with coffee buttercream and decorate with walnut halves.



Careen MacLennan
Kirkibost



POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - ZARA ARTS



I started Zara Arts portraits last year when I felt that my drawing skills were moving up to my own high standards and ready to be put out into the world. The name is after one of my old horses. I have been around horses all my life and it was them that inspired my drawing initially. I set a goal to be able to draw horses, most importantly my own pony at the time. I had people telling me that horses were the hardest animal to master in drawing....which whether it's true or not, I figured was a good starting point. I concluded if I can draw the most challenging animal, I will have the others in the bag, right? Zara was a horse that I feel taught me a lot about patience and determination, values I used every time I sat down to repeatedly draw horse hooves and the anatomy of noses. That is why she is used in my name and I believe it is very fitting.

From my drawing experience I started to branch out my art, drawing memorial portraits for some of my family's pets. There was a whole new feeling that came about having other people react to my work. Whether it was tears or smiles my art has made people happy and that is a highest honour that has boosted my confidence. I draw pets and animals using mainly coloured pencils. I love bringing to life their personalities and especially the eyes; there is something I find so satisfying and rewarding about getting an animal's eyes just right. I aim on giving people something a little different to put on their wall and represent their beloved pet.

You can contact me at livmarzShads2@gmail.com , 07799 677523 or on facebook messenger.



Olivia Marczak (16)
Kirkibost



CAISTEAL LOCH LÌOBHANN

Is dòcha gu bheil fios aig cuid agaibh gu bheil ùidh agam ann an eachdraidh. Mar sin bhithinn a' tadhal air aiteachan sònraichte, mar caistealan neo tobhtaichean neo tursachan.

Nuair a bha mi anns a' bhun-sgoil bhuannaich mi duais: leabhar snog "Teasairginn na Banrigh." 'S e sgeulachd a th' ann mu Màiri, Banrigh na h-Alba nuair a bha i na prìosanach aig Caisteal Loch Lìobhann. Bliadhnaichean às dèidh sin bha cothrom agam air dol dhan Caisteal le caraidean agus bha mi air bhioran a bhith a' coiseachd san aon aite far an robh a' Bhanrigh air fuireach linntean air ais.



Ghabh mi mòran thursan eile an sin a' sgrùdadh a h-uile pàirt de' n tobhta agus a' togail dealbhan gu leòr. Ach cha dìò chuimhnaich mi an turas mu dheireadh a-riamh. Chuir mi romham a dhol ann sa Chèitean. Cha b' fhada gus an do dh' ionnsaich mi gur e mearachd mòr a bha sin.

Bha mi a' feitheamh aig a' chidhe còmhla ri buidheann sgoilearan às an Fhraing agus fhuair sinn am bàta a-null don Eilean.

Nuair a bha sinn faisg air, cha b' urrainn dhuinn an Caisteal fhaicinn idir idir. Cha robh ach brat glas ann! Dè bha sin? Ceò? Smùid? Taibhsean? Bha iongantais air na balaich cuideachd. Fhuair sinn a-mach an fhìrinn cho luath 's a thàinig sinn air tìr.

Bha mìltean is mìltean de chuileagan - Cèitean ag itealaich tron adhar. Agus bha mìltean eile air na ballachan, air na beingean, air an fheur. Tha e fìor a radh gun robh iad anns a h-uile àite, timcheall air òirleach a dh' àirde!

Chan fhaca mi riamh a leithid!

Gun teagamh b'e cuairt gu math eadar - dhealaichte a bha siud.

Linne Macleod
Dun Innes



POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - FIRST SHOOTS AT CROFT 22

We have been residents for nearly 2 years but this year's growing season was our first on Bernera. In spite of being without buildings or a polycrub, we decided to experiment with crops and varieties of vegetables. With no anecdotal or other information to hand, we had no idea what would work or the quality of the soil.



We started by building a feed shed and tool storage out of pallets to house our tools, seeds, animal feed and gardening bits. Followed by making a 'polycrubboard' and covering a larger raised bed at the front with polysheeting remnants that were being thrown away. Seeds were planted in trays and potatoes chitted in the cupboard and then planted in one of the old lazybeds we had ploughed. Hopes of a good spring were soon dashed as we had 6 weeks of NE winds and although we had built loads of raised beds and planted them, nothing grew or seemed to progress at all. The dry summer has been a huge challenge to get the crops watered, as without mains water watering has been possible only because we had 2 tanks filled every month by our lovely neighbour's garden hose.

We have had some great successes and some notable failures, ranging from massive courgettes and zucca marrows, which have thrived outdoors, to flax growing successfully in the ploughed field alongside barley, potatoes and onions. Early

success came too in the form of Roman lettuce which has fed us for the entire summer; northern Italian spinach which has been delicious, and loads of mixed variety spring onions. Not so successful, but growing in the open nevertheless, has been the maize corn which did really well until the cooler, drier weather hit.

Growing well in the raised outdoor beds have been the peas, broad beans, turnips, radishes, beetroot, onions, nasturtiums, cabbages, Italian round carrots and chives. Sprouting broccoli, endive, butternut squash and kale are replacing those plants which are now harvested and eaten.

We swapped some blackthorn for gooseberry, blackcurrant and raspberry plants. We do have a crop of blackcurrants, though the others have struggled a bit with transplanting. Our 'tesco special' apple and plum trees are growing and had blossomed, before being chomped by the orphan lambs we have taken on.



New plants we've never grown before, like Scottish crowberries and artichokes, are thriving. In addition, we have planted 300 blackthorn, 660 willows, comfrey, clover, whitebeam and a hawthorne. Most seem to be thriving in spite of the lack of rain, though we envisage that only about half the willows will make it.

Some plants haven't done well at

all, such as the aubergines. The small buddleia plants also died in the late frost.

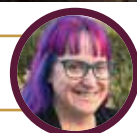


Definite failures have been basil, which has not enjoyed being outside, mint and lamb's lettuce which in spite of multiple attempts, have not grown. Not to mention our 2 Bernera News sunflower seeds which were doing really well, until the chickens escaped and ate them both.

A successful season of experimentation under our belts and with both water and electricity now on the croft, we can look forward to an interesting growing season next year. With our next plans afoot, Croft 22 is well on its way from being dormant to abundant.



Julia Higginbottom
Kirkibost



LONELY BUT NOT ALONE!

It is not often that I watch television but the other night I was privileged to view a specially commissioned documentary on BBC Alba. The topic was loneliness.

Various individuals and families were represented. Each told their own story and their challenge with feeling lonely, isolated, and forlorn.

One person become isolated from society due to addiction. In his case alcohol addiction. It became a despotic ruler whose influence separated him from his friends, his family and even from the island of his birth. Its power in his life was destructive, as all addictions are. Whether it is focussed upon monetary accrual, drug induced contentment, or the intoxicating oxygen of the celebrity of self.

Another person, a young mother of a small girl, along with her husband, spoke of the impact of Multiple Sclerosis upon her life, both personally and as a family. Her breath-taking honesty allowed the viewer a small insight into her life. So young and yet preparations being made for the power of attorney to be granted to her husband, once she would no longer be able to cognitively make clear decisions.

Her love for her little girl and husband and wider family so evident. And in the middle of all the challenges she faced she spoke of her MS inspired loneliness. An enemy that lurked in the background of her daily struggle to live effectively. Constantly seeking to discourage, demoralise and deflate her hope and her quality of life.

In both instances, one saw the destructive power of loneliness if left to its own devices. .

And as one has said, "You can be lonely in a crowd"!

The Christian is not immune from feeling lonely. A reality which the psalmist reveals when he wrote, that, 'I will say to God my Rock, "Why have You forgotten me?", **Psalms.42:8**

Yet, we are encouraged not to walk by sight but by faith. A faith, inspired by a grace-empowered hope that trusts wholeheartedly, in God's promise that 'He will never leave us nor forsake us'.

Reminding us that in Christ, although we may feel lonely, we are never alone, for the Pilgrim Saviour walks each step of the Way with us in our hearts, lovingly, continually, and eternally.

Rev Hugh Maurice Stewart
Uig & Bernera



GENERAL KNOWLEDGE QUIZ

1. British Isles most westerly island
2. International Scout camp every four years
3. Presenter of The Chase
4. Worlds oldest organisation for canine activities
5. The Hay Wain was painted by
6. The mint with the hole
7. When was the Bosta Iron Age Village active
8. Victor Meldrew was main character in
9. Christ was brought up here
10. A royal 'Mrs Brown'
11. Jason and Kylie married in this soap
12. French prophet wrote in quartans
13. Scottish Childrens Lottery draws on
14. POTUS is who
15. British arms highest honour
16. Who asked for more
17. The Beatles sang about this communist state
18. Footballs self-proclaimed special one
19. Britains first iron clad warship
20. Roman Emperor who successfully invaded Britain
21. And in which year
22. Genre of music The Stranglers known for
23. A country with no coast is what
24. Bicycle with one huge wheel and one small
25. US equivalent of 999
26. Landseer painting of a regal stag
27. Known as the naked chef
28. Patriarch of C16 Scottish cannibal family
29. The lead singer of The Police
30. The Alien who 'phoned home'

Colin Halliday
Kirkibost

